From Mitzrayim to Closeness

A Pesach Reflection on Memory, Growth, and Hakaras HaTov

I. The emotion of Erev Pesach

Erev Pesach carries a very specific kind of energy. The house is already cleaned, the *chametz* burned, the *bitul* said. The last few hours are filled with movement, with pressure, with final preparations. Showers, *mikvah*, food, table, everything coming together at once. And within all of that, there is something deeper, something emotional that sits just beneath the surface.

Pesach, for me, has always been my favorite *Chag*. Growing up in Northern California, Pesach meant traveling. It meant going to Baltimore, sometimes down to Florida, gathering with cousins, aunts, and uncles. Not always everyone, but enough to feel that fullness, that warmth, that sense of being surrounded by the people who make up your world. It was alive, it was joyful, and it left a deep imprint. Even now, thinking back, there is both a strong sense of positivity and also a quiet sense of longing for something that cannot fully be recreated.

That combination is not incidental. It is exactly what Pesach is meant to evoke.

II. Why do we focus on the negative?

In the middle of all this preparation, my daughter asked a simple but powerful question. Why do we spend so much time focusing on the negative?

As we move through *Chumash*, and even further into *Nach*, we see a repeated pattern. *Klal Yisrael* rises, and then falls. There is strength, and then there is failure. The *Avos* build something extraordinary, and then we descend into Mitzrayim. We leave Mitzrayim, and then we struggle in the *Midbar*. The *meraglim*, the complaints, the setbacks. It is a constant cycle of ascent and descent across the whole of our history.

For a child, this is difficult to process. Why not focus only on the good?

But as adults, we begin to understand that this pattern is not a weakness in the narrative. It is the very foundation of *hakaras hatov*, of genuine gratitude. Without contrast, appreciation cannot exist. A person who has only ever known comfort has no framework

for recognizing what they have been given. It is the experience of the narrow place that makes the open space feel like what it truly is: a gift.

Pesach begins from exactly that place.

עֲבָדִים הָיִינוּ לְפַרְעֹה בְּמִצְרָיִם

"We were slaves to Pharaoh in Egypt." — Haggadah, Maggid

Not as a historical footnote. Not as something that happened to other people long ago. But as the starting point of identity. As a people, we reached a place of constriction, of limitation, of dependence. And from there, Hashem took us out.

Everything begins there. Because if I want to live in alignment with the *ratzon Hashem*, if I want to grow day by day, then I must be willing to remember where I came from. Growth is not built on perfection. It is built on awareness. And awareness requires honesty about both the descent and the ascent.

III. Preparing to leave Mitzrayim

Pesach is not only a memory. It is a process.

Bedikas chametz is not only about searching for crumbs. It is a *cheshbon hanefesh*, an honest accounting of the self. What within me is blocking my connection with Hashem? What needs to be found and named before it can be removed?

תַּשְׁבִּיתוּ שְׂאֹר מִבָּתֵּיכֶם

"You shall eliminate the leaven from your homes." — Shemos 12:15

Biur chametz is the next step. Not just identifying those barriers, but actively clearing them. The *se'or*, the leaven, is understood in our tradition as a metaphor for the *yetzer hara* itself — for the inner inflation, the habits and the pride that puff us up and keep us distant. The work of Erev Pesach is the work of making space.

And then comes the preparation of the self. The *mikvah*, the physical act of *taharah*, reflects an internal readiness. I am not entering the *Chag* casually. I am preparing to step into something elevated. The body is being aligned with the intention of the soul.

In the times of the *Beis HaMikdash*, this preparation reached its fullest expression in the *Korban Pesach*. This was not just another *korban*. It required precision, intention, and participation. People gathered in *chaburos*, structured groups, each person needing to be

present and engaged in a defined way. You could not bring the *Korban Pesach* alone. It was, by its nature, a communal act.

שֶׂה לְבֵית אָבֹת שֶׂה לַבָּיִת

"A lamb for each household, a lamb for each home." — Shemos 12:3

Before engaging with the *korban*, a person had to prepare themselves. And only after that preparation could they enter into the moment of *kedushah* and closeness that the *korban* represented. The sequence mattered. The order was not arbitrary.

IV. The Seder as a journey upward

Today, we no longer have the *Korban Pesach*. But we were given something extraordinary in its place. The Seder.

The Seder is not merely symbolic. It is structured. It is exact. It is a process of transformation, designed to move a person from one state of being to another. The very word *seder* means order, and that order is not incidental. Every step builds on the one before it.

We begin with *Kadesh*. We declare that time itself is not passive. We are given the ability to be *mekadesh*, to sanctify, to partner with Hashem in defining the moment as something set apart from the ordinary.

מְקַדֵּשׁ יִשְׂרָאֵל וְהַזְּמַנִּים

"Who sanctifies Israel and the seasons." — Kiddush, Yom Tov

Then *Urchatz*, preparing the body again. Then *Karpas*: a vegetable, something from the earth, dipped in salt water. We begin at the lowest level intentionally. We acknowledge that we come from the ground, that we are creatures of this world. The salt water carries the memory of tears.

From there, we arrive at *Yachatz*. We break the middle *matzah*. And this is not simply a practical step in the Seder. It is something much deeper.

There is a concept in *Kabbalah* known as *sheviras hakeilim*, the breaking of the vessels. The vessels that were created to contain the divine light could not hold what was poured into them, and so they shattered. And it was precisely through that shattering that

something new became possible. The breaking was not a failure. It was the necessary precondition for rebuilding at a higher level.

Yachatz carries that same energy. Up until this point in the Seder, we have started from the lowest levels, from the most basic forms of existence. But a person cannot remain there indefinitely. There are moments in life where growth does not come from gradual improvement alone. It comes from being willing to break through what has become limiting, what has become a container too small for where we are being called to go. *Yachatz* is that moment. I am not staying confined within the level I began in. I am willing to break what is holding me back in order to move toward something higher, something closer, something more aligned with the *ratzon Hashem*.

The broken piece is not discarded. It becomes the *afikoman*, hidden away, searched for, and found only at the end of the night. What was broken is also what completes the Seder. What we shattered is what we were looking for all along.

And then *Maggid*. Now we speak. Now we tell the story.

וְהִגַּדְתָּ לְבִנְךָ בַּיּוֹם הַהוּא

"And you shall tell your child on that day." — Shemos 13:8

The telling is not informational. It is transformational. It turns history into identity. And it begins with questions. *Mah Nishtanah* is not just a children's exercise. Questions create awareness. They force reflection. They open a space inside a person that simply reading or reciting cannot. When we ask, we become actively present in the story rather than passive observers of it.

We move through the narrative: the sages in Bnei Brak who spoke through the entire night, the four sons, the unfolding of the plagues and the redemption. And only then do we arrive at *Dayenu* — a level of appreciation so deep that even a single step of the redemption would have been enough.

And what makes it enough? Because we first passed through the darkness. Because we remember what it was like to have nothing. Because

עֲבָדִים הָיִינוּ

"We were slaves" — is not just the beginning of the Haggadah. It is the lens through which everything that follows is seen.

V. From bitterness to clarity

The Haggadah then anchors us in the three core symbols that Rabban Gamliel teaches are essential for fulfilling the Seder:

כָּל שֶׁלֹּא אָמַר שְׁלֹשָׁה דְּבָרִים אֵלּוּ בְּפֶסַח לֹא יָצָא יְדֵי חוֹבָתוֹ

"Whoever has not said these three things on Pesach has not fulfilled his obligation." — Pesachim 10:5

Pesach, Matzah, and Maror. The *korban* and the redemption. The *matzah* of haste and humility. The *maror* of bitterness. These are not three separate ideas arranged for convenience. They are one process, three dimensions of a single truth. You cannot have the redemption without first having sat with the bitterness. You cannot appreciate the *matzah* without understanding the constriction it was baked within.

בְּכָל דּוֹר וָדוֹר חַיָּב אָדָם לִרְאוֹת אֶת עַצְמוֹ כְּאִלּוּ הוּא יָצָא מִמִּצְרָיִם

"In every generation, a person is obligated to see himself as though he personally left Egypt." — Pesachim 10:5

Mitzrayim is not only a place. It is a state. It is every place in life where a person feels constrained, stuck, unable to move forward. Every generation has its own Mitzrayim. Every person carries their own narrow place. And the only way out is through awareness, through memory, through an honest recognition of both the struggle and the redemption.

VI. Growth requires contrast

This brings us back to the original question. Why do we focus on the negative?

Because without it, there is nothing to appreciate. Without it, there is no movement. Without the awareness of where we were, we cannot feel the full weight of where we are.

If everything were always easy, if every day were the same, there would be no growth. There would be no reason to strive, no reason to change. The very friction of life is what produces the yearning that drives us forward.

Personally, I am not on the level where everything is automatically seen as good, where every experience is clearly and immediately recognizable as the *ratzon Hashem*. I am not there yet. But I can reflect. I can remember what I have been through. And those memories allow me to appreciate where I am today, and to want to continue growing from here.

If I am truly appreciative of what Hashem has done for me, then I naturally want to be closer to Him. Everything circles back to that. Appreciation is not the end of the journey. It is the fuel for the next step.

VII. A parent's role, a nation's journey

As a parent, this becomes even more immediate. I do not want my children to experience suffering in order to learn appreciation. But I do want to give them the tools to navigate a world that will not always be easy.

To recognize light even when there is darkness. To grow upward even when things are difficult. To understand that the hard moments are not evidence that something has gone wrong, but often the very terrain through which growth happens.

The Seder is one of the most powerful tools we have for transmitting this. It is not a passive recitation. It is a system that trains a person how to think, how to feel, how to ask, and how to grow. When a child sits at the Seder table and asks *Mah Nishtanah*, something is being planted. When a parent answers with the full story, something is being passed down. Not just information, but orientation. A way of seeing the world.

I do not need to give my daughter the full weight of every difficulty. But I do need to give her the *kelim*, the vessels, to hold whatever comes. A person with the right *kelim* can carry hard things without being broken by them. The Seder is, among other things, the annual transmission of those vessels from one generation to the next.

And if we move through it properly, with awareness and intention, something shifts. Not only in what we know, but in who we are.

VIII. Toward Yerushalayim

At the very end of the Seder, after everything — after the *Hallel* and the songs and the four cups and the long journey of the night — we say:

לְשָׁנָה הַבָּאָה בִּירוּשָׁלָיִם

"Next year in Jerusalem." — Haggadah, Nirtzah

This is not only about geography. It is about completion. It is the articulation of a redemption that is still unfolding. A world with the *Beis HaMikdash*, with the *Korban*

Pesach, with Mashiach. But also something immediate and personal. The Mitzrayim that we ourselves have left behind this year. The narrow place we have moved through. The step toward closeness that this Seder made possible.

Because the word *korban* comes from *karov* — to come close. Every *korban* was, at its root, an act of approach. And that is the essence of Pesach as well. Not just remembering the redemption. Not just telling the story. But moving, step by step, through a structured order, toward genuine closeness with Hashem.

The Haggadah gives us the structure. The questions are already there. And if we go through it properly, with open eyes and an open heart, we will find ourselves asking even more questions than the ones already written. That is not a sign that something is missing. That is a sign that something is alive.

Chag kasher v'sameach. May this Pesach bring each of us one step closer.